Topic 3 — Indian Architecture

Covers syllabus (click to expand)

Indian Temple Architecture | Nagara Style | Dravida Style | Vesara Style | Temple Architecture | Gupta Period Temples | Pallava and Chola Temples | Buddhist Architecture | Stupa | Chaitya | Vihara | Rock-cut Architecture | Cave Architecture | Indo-Islamic Architecture | Mughal Architecture | Ancient Indian Architecture | Medieval Indian Architecture | Taj Mahal | Qutub Minar | Konark Sun Temple | Khajuraho | Brihadeeswara | Sanchi Stupa | Mahabalipuram | Ajanta & Ellora | Elephanta Caves

Sources: NCERT An Introduction to Indian Art (Class 11), Themes I–III, ASI/UNESCO, Ghatnachakra Architecture in Ancient India (B–153+), UPPCS Prelims PYQs 2018–2025 **Last verified:** September 2026

Current Affairs

- The **Ancient Buddhist Site of Sarnath** in Uttar Pradesh entered the UNESCO World Heritage list in **July 2026** at the 48th World Heritage Committee session in Busan.
- Sarnath is India's **45th** World Heritage property. The serial site joins **Chaukhandi Stupa** with the archaeological remains around **Dhamek** (धमेख) and the Ashokan pillar zone.
- **Maratha Military Landscapes of India** entered the list in **2025** as India's **44th** property. The set covers **12** forts: eleven in Maharashtra and **Gingee** in Tamil Nadu.
- **Moidams – the Mound-Burial System of the Ahom Dynasty** at Charaideo in Assam entered the list in **2024** as India's **43rd** property.
- These recent World Heritage inscriptions reflect India's architectural, fortificatory, and funerary landscape heritage.

3.1 Indian Temple Architecture

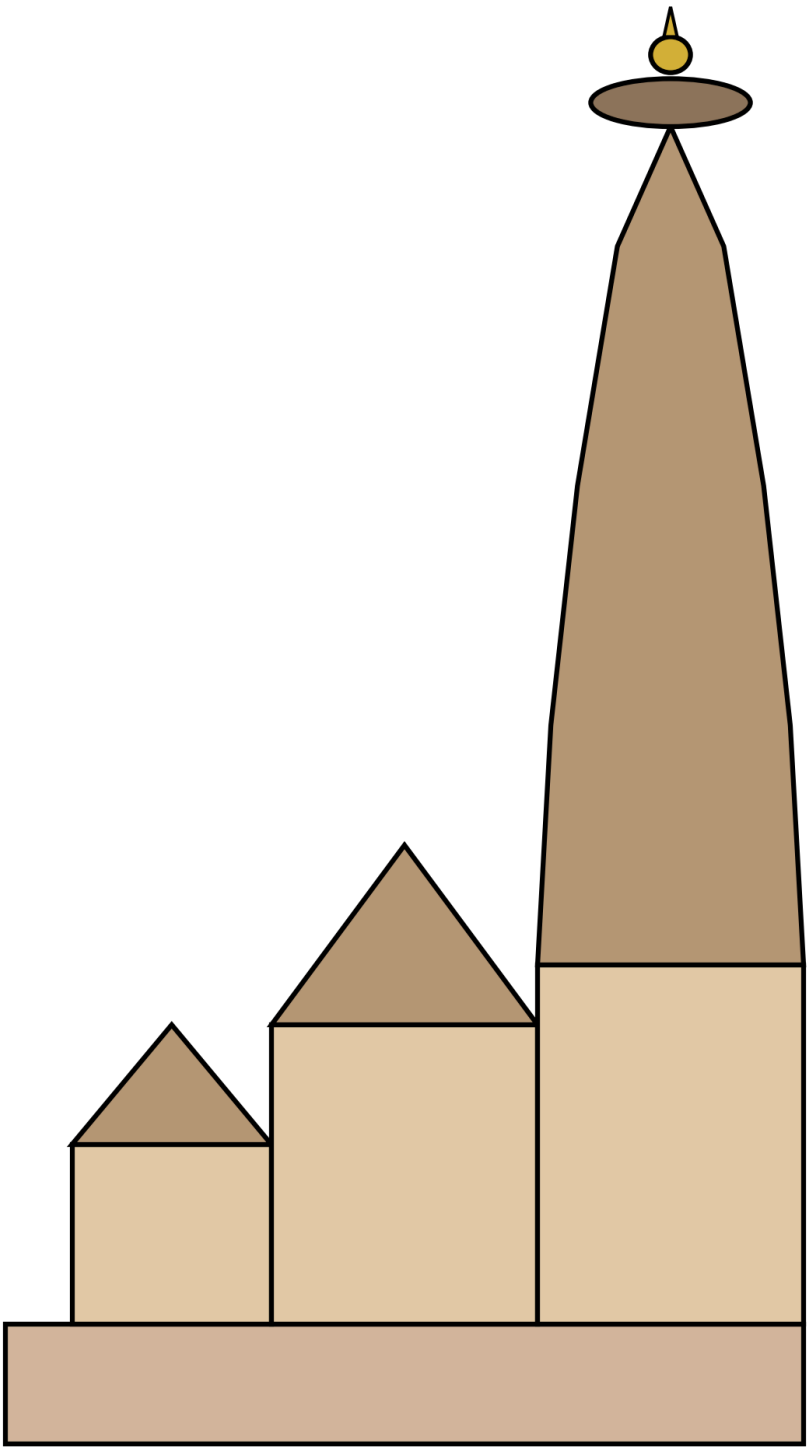
Meaning: A Hindu temple is the house of the deity. The usual plan runs east to west from the gateway into the garbhagriha. This card also covers the syllabus head **Temple Architecture**.

- The **adhishthana** or **jagati** is the raised platform on which the shrine sits.
- The **garbhagriha** (गर्भगृह) is the sanctum. It is the darkest inner chamber and holds the main *murti*.
- A **shikhara** (शिखर) is the tower over the sanctum in the **Nagara** style.
- A **vimana** (विमान) is the tower over the sanctum in the **Dravida** style.
- An **urushringa** is a miniature shikhara clustered on a Nagara tower. Khajuraho uses this clustering.
- The **antarala** (अंतराल) is the vestibule between the hall and the sanctum.
- An **ardha-mandapa** is the porch.

- A **maha-mandapa** is the main pillared hall.
- A **natya-mandapa** is a hall for dance.
- A **sabha-mandapa** is an assembly hall.
- The **pradakshina patha** (प्रदक्षिणा पथ) is the path for clockwise walking around the sanctum.
- A **sandhara** temple has an ambulatory around the sanctum.
- A **nirandhara** temple has no ambulatory.
- A **gopuram** (गोपुरम) is a gateway tower. It is a **Dravida** hallmark, not a Nagara one.
- A **prakara** is the enclosure wall around a Dravida temple campus.
- An **amalaka** (आमलक) is the ribbed stone disc that crowns a Nagara shikhara.
- A **kalasha** (कलश) sits above the amalaka as the finial.
- A Dravida finial is called a *stupika* or *kalasam*.
- In Odisha, a **ratha** is a vertical offset on the deul wall. Temples may be triratha, pancharatha, or saptaratha.
- That Odisha **ratha** is not the Pallava granite monolith called a ratha at Mahabalipuram.
- **Dvarapalas** are door guardians carved at the sanctum entrance.
- **Mithuna** couples appear on outer walls of developed Nagara temples, as at Khajuraho.
- **Panchayatana** (पंचायतन) places a central shrine with four smaller shrines at the corners. Gupta Deogarh is the early type.
- **Nagara** is the north Indian style, mainly north of the Vindhyas.
- **Dravida** is the south Indian style.
- **Vesara** is the Deccan and Karnataka hybrid.

> **Logic:** Konark and Khajuraho are **Nagara**. Brihadeeswara and the Shore Temple are **Dravida**. Belur and Halebidu are **Vesara / Hoysala**. A gopuram is a gateway. A shikhara is the north Indian sanctum tower. Do not swap those two words.

3.2 Nagara Style



Nagara temples belong to North India. The tower is a curvilinear **shikhara**. There is generally no monumental gopuram.

- **Latina** is the simple curvilinear sanctum tower.
- **Phamsana** is a stepped pyramidal roof, usually over the mandapa.
- **Valabhi** (वलभी) is a barrel-roof form. **Teli ka Mandir** at Gwalior is the usual example.
- Odisha calls the sanctum tower a **rekha deul** (रेखा देउल).
- Odisha calls the jagamohana hall a **pidha deul** (पीढ़ा देउल).
- **Khakhara** is a rectangular Odisha roof. **Vaital Deul** at Bhubaneswar is the type example.
- **Parasuramesvara** at Bhubaneswar is the earliest standing Odisha temple, about the 7th–8th century.
- **Mukteshvara** follows it. Coaching notes call it a gem and point to its ornate *torana* (तोरण).
- **Rajarani** is the next named shrine in the Bhubaneswar sequence.
- **Lingaraja** is an 11th-century pancharatha temple at Bhubaneswar. It is the tallest standing temple in that city, about **180** feet.
- **Jagannath** at Puri comes next in the Odisha order.
- The Jagannath triad of Jagannath, Balabhadra, and Subhadra is of **neem wood**. The images are renewed in the nabakalebara cycle.
- **Konark** is the last great shrine in that Odisha order. It belongs to the 13th century.
- **Khajuraho** is a **Chandela** sandstone Nagara group in **Madhya Pradesh**, built in the **10th–12th** centuries. It is not in Uttar Pradesh.
- About **85** shrines were planned at Khajuraho. About **25** still stand.
- The groups are Hindu (Shaiva, Vaishnava, and Shakta) and Jain.
- The **Chausath Yogini** at Khajuraho is the oldest shrine in that group. It is hypaethral, which means it is open to the sky.
- The Khajuraho Chausath Yogini is not the circular temple at **Morena**.
- **Matangeshvara** is a Shiva-linga temple of **Dhanga's** age. It is still in active worship.
- **Lakshmana** is a Vaishnava temple built under **Yashovarman**.
- **Vishvanatha** is a major western-group Shiva temple at Khajuraho.
- **Chitragupta** is the Surya temple of the western group.
- **Devi Jagadambi** stands in the western group.
- **Lalguan Mahadeva** is a smaller western shrine.
- **Brahma** temple at Khajuraho is a named western-group shrine.
- **Kandariya Mahadeva** is the largest Khajuraho temple. **Vidyadhara** built it in the 11th century.
- **Parshvanatha** (पार्श्वनाथ) is an eastern Jain temple at Khajuraho.
- **Adinatha** is another eastern Jain temple there.
- **Ghantai** is the third named eastern Jain shrine.
- **Duladeo** belongs to the southern group.
- **Chaturbhuja** also belongs to the southern group.
- **Modhera** Sun Temple was built by Solanki **Bhima I**. It is known for its Surya kund.

- **Rani ki Vav** at Patan is a Solanki stepwell. UNESCO listed it in **2014**. It reads as an inverted temple of seven storeys.
- **Dilwara** at Mount Abu in Rajasthan is a set of white **marble** Jain temples of the same Solanki milieu.
- **Vimal Vasahi** at Dilwara honours Adinatha. **Vimal Shah**, a feudatory of Bhima I, built it.
- **Luna Vasahi** at Dilwara honours Neminatha. Vastupal and Tejpal built it.
- **Palitana** is a Jain tirtha on **Shatrunjaya** hill near Bhavnagar in Gujarat. The main dedication is to **Adinatha**.
- **Sonagiri** near Datia in Madhya Pradesh is a Digambar Jain hill of about **103** temples. Main shrine number 57 honours **Chandraprabhu**.
- **Martand** Sun Temple was built by **Lalitaditya** in Kashmir. It is a sun temple, not a Gangetic latina Nagara shrine.
- **Teli ka Mandir** at Gwalior mixes a Valabhi barrel look with a Dravida-type pinnacle and northern ornament. Treat it as a fusion trap.
- **Bishnupur** terracotta temples belong to the Malla kings of Bengal. They use *ratna* and *chala* roofs.
- The sun-temple set to remember is **Konark**, **Modhera**, **Martand**, and **Arasavalli** in Andhra.
- **Amarkantak** and **Omkareshwar** are Shiva centres. They are distractors in sun-temple lists.

Morena Chausath Yogini

Kachchhapaghata Devapala | Morena, Madhya Pradesh | circular hypaethral plan

- This circular temple is separate from the Khajuraho Chausath Yogini.
- Popular belief links the circular plan to the design of the Indian Parliament building.
- It is not the only circular temple in India.
- It is not a Vaishnava cult shrine.

Konark Sun Temple

Narasimhadeva I (Eastern Ganga) | 13th century | Odisha | UNESCO 1984

- Konark is a stone **chariot** of Surya. It has **24** wheels and **7** horses.
- The composition is a rekha deul with a pidha jagamohana.
- European sailors called it the **Black Pagoda**. They called Jagannath Puri the White Pagoda.
- Konark is Nagara, not Dravida. It is not in Uttar Pradesh.

Khajuraho Group

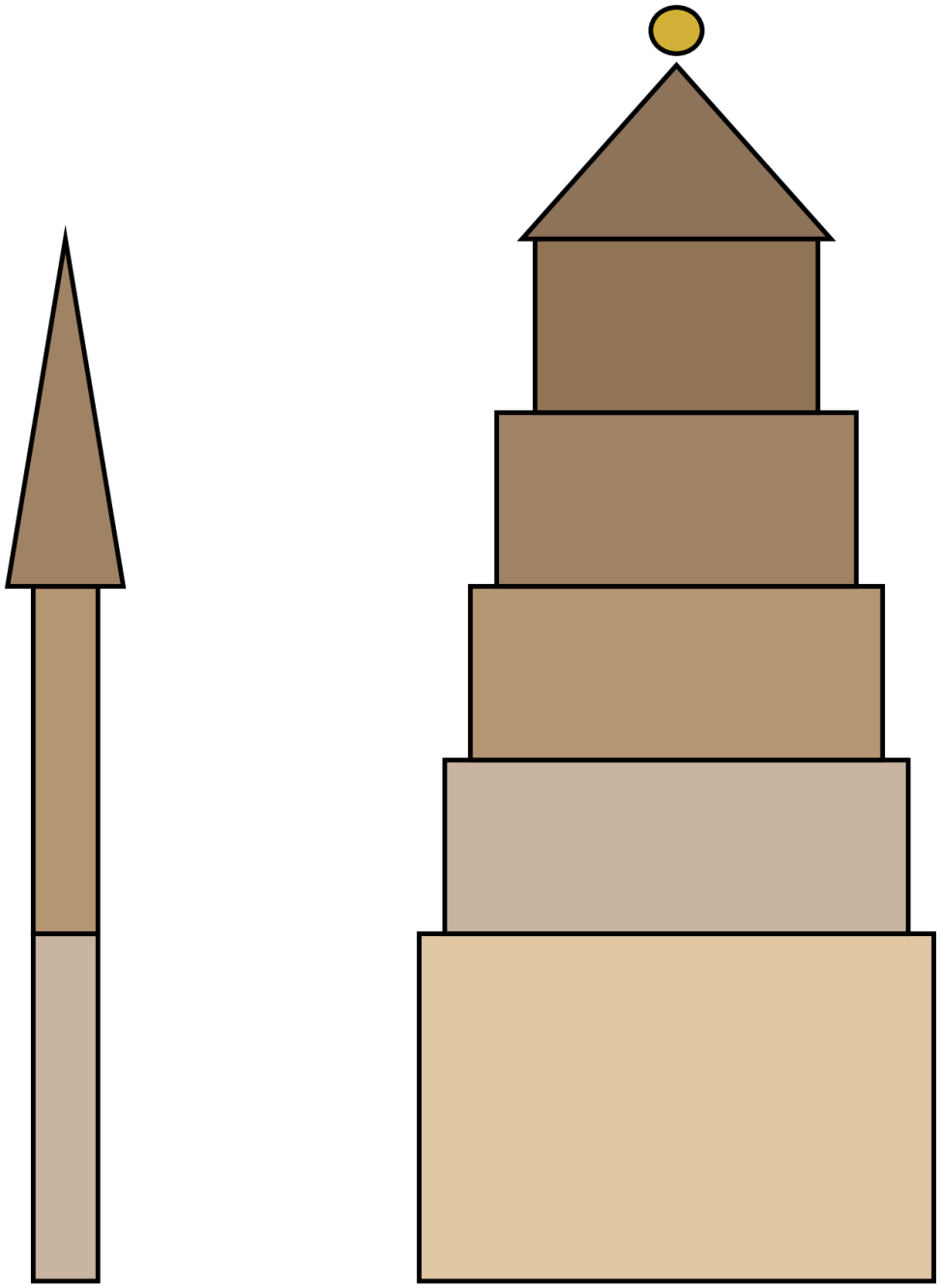
Chandela | 10th–12th century | Madhya Pradesh | UNESCO 1986

- The campus has a western Hindu group, an eastern Jain group, and a southern group.
- Erotic *mithuna* figures sit on the exterior. The sanctum remains a sacred chamber.
- All compartments of a developed Khajuraho temple connect internally and externally. Coaching notes treat this as a style point.
- **Markandeshwar** at Gadchiroli in Vidarbha is called the **Khajuraho of Vidarbha**. It is not Kailasa. It is not Bhimashankar.
- Madhya Pradesh World Heritage sites often tested with Khajuraho are **Bhimbetka** and **Sanchi**.

- **Mandu** is not a World Heritage Site.

> [!TIP] **Exam Anchor [UPPCS Prelims 2019, Q109]: Markandeshwar Temple** on Wainganga River (Gadchiroli, Maharashtra) is celebrated as the "Khajuraho of Vidarbha" (built 9th–12th century). *(See Q7 in Complete PYQ Bank below)*

3.3 Dravida Style



Dravida temples belong to the Tamil country and the south. The tower is a pyramidal **vimana** over the sanctum. The gateway is a tall **gopuram**.

- A Dravida campus sits inside an enclosure called a *prakara*, entered through gopurams.
- Under the **Pandya** and later **Nayaka** (नायक) rulers of Madurai, the outer gopurams become the dominant face and can dwarf the vimana.
- **Meenakshi** at Madurai has **12** gopurams. The southern tower is about **52** metres high.
- Tradition links the original Meenakshi shrine with **Kulasekara Pandya**. The gopuram peak is **Nayaka**. This is not a Pallava foundation.
- The vimana is storeyed. Each storey is a *tala* (ताल). The finial is a *kalasam*. *Kudu* arches look like horseshoes.
- Pallava and Chola structural temples use **granite**. Later Nayaka gopurams often use brick and stucco.
- **Rameshwaram** is known for the longest temple corridor in this style.
- **Srivilliputhur** is known for one of the tallest gopurams.
- **Chidambaram** is the Nataraja temple of the Chola–later Dravida world.
- **Ekambareswarar** at Kanchi is a Dravida Shiva temple.
- **Varadaraja** at Kanchi is a Dravida Vishnu temple.

> **Logic:** The Shore Temple and Brihadeeswara are **structural Dravida**. They are not rock-cut. The *rathas* beside the Shore Temple are rock-cut.

3.4 Vesara Style

Karnataka and the Deccan | Vesara hybrid of Nagara and Dravida

- **Aihole** is remembered as the cradle of early Indian temple experiment under the Early Chalukyas.
- The **Durga** temple at Aihole reuses an apsidal chaitya plan.
- The **Lad Khan** temple is an early Chalukya hall-shrine at Aihole.
- The **Huchimalli** temple is another early experiment at Aihole.
- The **Meguti** temple at Aihole is Jain. Ravikirti's Aihole inscription of Pulakeshin II, dated **634 CE**, is here.
- **Badami** has four caves. Cave 1 is Shaiva. Caves 2 and 3 are Vaishnava. Cave 4 is Jain.
- **Pattadakal** is a UNESCO coronation site from **1987**. Nagara and Dravida temples stand together there.
- **Virupaksha** at Pattadakal is Dravida. Vikramaditya II and queen Lokamahadevi built it on the model of Kanchi Kailasanatha.
- **Papanatha** at Pattadakal leans toward Nagara.
- **Chennakeshava** at Belur is a Hoysala temple of **Vishnuvardhana**.
- **Hoysaleswara** at Halebidu is a Hoysala twin-shrine temple.
- **Kesava** at Somnathpur is a Hoysala temple of **Narasimha III**.

- Hoysala work uses soapstone, a **star or stellate** plan, and lathe-turned pillars. UNESCO listed the Hoysala ensemble in **2023**.
- **Ramappa / Rudreshwara** at Palampet is **Kakatiya**, listed by UNESCO in **2021**. It uses floating bricks. It is not Hoysala.

> **Logic:** Vesara is not a fourth pan-Indian style equal to "Mughal." If a stem says Karnataka hybrid or Chalukya–Hoysala, choose Vesara.

3.5 Gupta Period Temples

Gupta temples are the first **structural** freestanding stone and brick temples in the north. They belong to the fourth to sixth centuries.

- Freestanding mortar-and-stone or brick temples are remembered as beginning in the **Gupta** age. They are not Mauryan rock-cut work.
- Early Gupta shrines are flat-roofed. A simple shikhara then appears. **Panchayatana** also appears.
- **Dashavatara** at **Deogarh** (Lalitpur region, Uttar Pradesh–Madhya Pradesh border) is a Vishnu temple. It is early Nagara and a classic panchayatana plan.
- **Bhitargaon** in Kanpur Dehat, **Uttar Pradesh** (उत्तर प्रदेश), is a **brick** temple with terracotta panels. It is Gupta or late Gupta and among India's oldest brick temples.
- **Temple 17** at Sanchi is an early flat-roofed stone shrine.
- **Tigawa** (Kankali Devi) in Madhya Pradesh is a Gupta shrine.
- **Nachna-Kuthara** holds a Gupta Parvati temple.
- **Bhumara** in Madhya Pradesh is a Gupta Shiva temple.
- **Eran** in Madhya Pradesh holds Gupta Vishnu and Varaha remains.
- **Garhwa** at Shankargarh in **Prayagraj** (प्रयागराज), Uttar Pradesh, holds Gupta temple-complex remains.
- **Udayagiri** (उदयगिरि) near Vidisha in Madhya Pradesh has Gupta cave-temples. The Varaha panel belongs to Chandragupta II.

> **Logic:** Gupta work begins the Hindu structural temple. Bhitargaon is the Uttar Pradesh brick example. Gupta rock-cut work is Udayagiri, not Ajanta. Ajanta's Mahayana phase is Vakataka. Dashavatara is not at Khajuraho.

3.6 Pallava and Chola Temples

Pallava

Kanchi | granite | Mahabalipuram and Kanchipuram

- Pallava temple work runs **Mahendra** rock-cut mandapas, then **Mamalla** monolith rathas, then **Rajasimha** structural temples, then **Nandivarman**.
- **Mahendravarman I** (महेन्द्रवर्मन प्रथम) left the Mandagapattu inscription. It records the first rock-cut shrine made without brick, timber, or metal.
- The **Pancha Rathas** belong to **Narasimhavarman I** (Mamalla). They are cut downward from one granite outcrop.
- Colonial lists also call that ratha set the **Seven Rathas** or **Sapt Pagoda**.
- **Dharmaraja ratha** is the largest. Its roof is pyramidal.
- **Bhima ratha** has a barrel or valabhi roof.
- **Draupadi ratha** is hut-shaped and dedicated to Durga. It is the **smallest** of the set. Little ornament covers it. Lion or elephant-like sculptures sit around it.
- The **Shore Temple** belongs to **Rajasimha**. It is structural, not rock-cut. It holds two Shiva shrines and a reclining Vishnu. UNESCO lists it with the Mahabalipuram monuments.
- **Arjuna's Penance**, also called Descent of the Ganga, is the huge open-air rock relief at Mamallapuram.
- **Kailasanatha** (कैलासनाथ) at Kanchi is Rajasimha's sandstone proto-Dravida temple. Tradition says Mahendravarman II completed work on it.

Chola

Chola temples are imperial structural Dravida in granite. Inscriptions on the walls explain why we know more about the Cholas than their predecessors.

- The early Chola **Korangnath** temple at **Srinivasanallur** belongs to **Parantaka I**.
- **Brihadeeswara**, also called Rajarajeshwara, at Thanjavur was built by **Rajaraja I** in **1003–1010 CE**. The fabric is granite.
- The Thanjavur vimana is about **66** metres high and has **13** storeys. The *kalasam* is a monolith.
- The colossal **Nandi** is carved from a single rock and is counted among the tallest Nandi idols in India.
- Two **dvarapala** figures stand near the main shrine. The temple is **Dravida**, not Nagara.
- **Gangaikonda Cholapuram** was built by **Rajendra I** about **1025–1035**, after the Ganges campaign.
- **Airavatesvara** at Darasuram belongs to **Rajaraja II**.
- UNESCO's Great Living Chola Temples, listed in **1987**, are Thanjavur, Gangaikonda Cholapuram, and Darasuram.
- **Koranganatha Temple** at Srinivasanallur (Tiruchirappalli district, Tamil Nadu) was constructed during the reign of early Chola monarch **Parantaka I**.
- The south-temple chronology to ratta is **Sapt Pagoda (7th century) → Shore Temple (early 8th) → Brihadeeswara (1010) → Gangaikonda Cholapuram (about 1035)**.

> [!TIP] **Exam Anchor [UPPCS Prelims 2018, Q15]:** Chronological order of temples: **Brihadisvara (Thanjavur, Rajaraja I, 1010) → Gangaikonda Cholapuram (Rajendra I, ~1035) → Shore Temple (Mamallapuram, Narasimhavarman II Rajasimha, early 8th c.) → Saptaratha (Mamallapuram, Narasimhavarman I Mahamalla, mid 7th c.)**. *(See Q8 in Complete PYQ Bank below)*

> [!TIP] **Exam Anchor [UPPCS Prelims 2020, Q8]:** Assertion: Most Gupta temples built of stone; Bhitargaon (Kanpur) and Sirpur Lakshmana temple (Chhattisgarh) are rare baked-brick Gupta structures. *(See Q5 in Complete PYQ Bank below)*

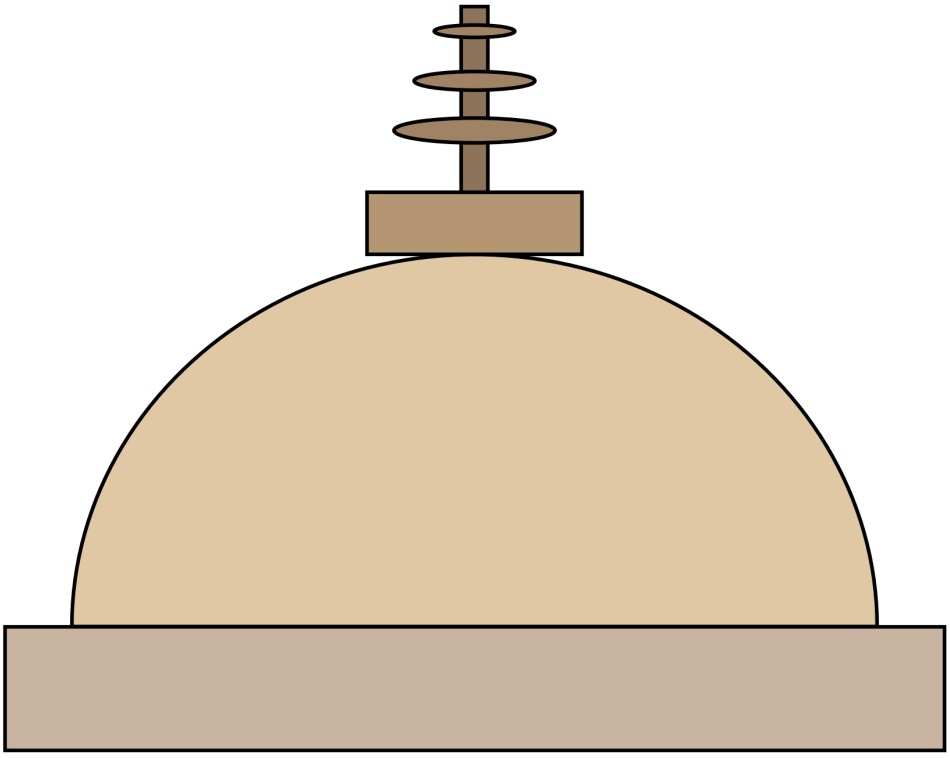
3.7 Buddhist Architecture

The Buddhist trio is the **stupa** (relic mound), the **chaitya** (prayer hall), and the **vihara** (monastery).

- Buddhist sacred building comes in three types. Papers treat them as three different statements.
- A **stupa** is a solid relic mound. Devotees walk around it.
- A **chaitya** is a congregational hall. A stupa sits in its apse.
- A **vihara** is a monastery. Monks live in cells around a courtyard or hall.
- One site can hold all three. Sanchi is a stupa campus. Karle is a chaitya. Ajanta is mostly viharas plus a few chaityas.

> **Logic:** Stupa means mound. Chaitya means a hall with a stupa inside. Vihara means monastery. Never swap the three.

3.8 Stupa



A stupa is a solid relic mound. From bottom to top the parts are *medhi*, then *anda*, then *harmika*, then *yashti* with *chhatra*.

- A **vedika** is the rail around a stupa.
- A **torana** (तोरण) is a gateway.
- The **pradakshina patha** is the walking path.
- **Sanchi Stupa 1** has an Ashokan brick core. The **Shungas** enlarged it.
- Four **toranas** at Sanchi belong to the Satavahana age. The **south torana is the oldest**.
- Early Sanchi is **aniconic** (अप्रतिमेय). The Buddha appears as a lotus, footprints, or an empty throne. UNESCO listed Sanchi in **1989**. It is in **Madhya Pradesh**, not Uttar Pradesh.
- **Bharhut** in Madhya Pradesh is a Shunga railing campus. Much of the railing is now in the **Indian Museum, Kolkata**.
- **Dhamek** at **Sarnath** in Uttar Pradesh is Gupta brick-and-stone. It marks the first sermon. UNESCO listed the Sarnath serial in **2026**.
- **Chaukhandi** at Sarnath is later commemorative. An octagonal Mughal tower sits on an ancient base.
- **Mahabodhi** at Bodh Gaya is a brick tower over the enlightenment seat. UNESCO listed it in **2002**. It is not an ayaka-stupa.
- **Amaravati** in Andhra has **ayaka platforms** with **five pillars** at the four cardinals. It is the type-site for that form.

- **Nagarjunakonda** (नागार्जुनकोंडा) belongs to the same ayaka family.
- **Ghantasala** belongs to the same ayaka family.
- **Jaggayyapeta** belongs to the same ayaka family.
- **Bodh Gaya has no ayaka pillars.**
- **Vaishali** is a relic-stupa site.
- **Piprahwa** is a relic-casket site.
- **Kesariya** in Bihar is the tallest stupa in India.

> [!TIP] **Exam Anchor [UPPCS Prelims 2022, Q80]:** Ayaka platforms with 5 pillars (symbolising 5 life-events of Buddha) are unique to Andhra Ikshvaku stupas (**Amaravati** & **Jaggayyapeta**). *(See Q4 in Complete PYQ Bank below)*

3.9 Chaitya

A chaitya is an apsidal prayer hall. It has a nave and aisles, a stupa in the apse, and a ribbed vault.

- A chaitya is not the free-standing stupa. The hall contains a stupa.
- **Karle**, also called Karla, near Lonavala is the **largest** surviving Hinayana chaitya.
- **Bhaja** (भाजा) is very early. Its vault imitates wooden ribs.
- **Bedsa** (बेडसा) is a western-ghat Hinayana chaitya.
- **Kondane** is a western-ghat Hinayana chaitya.
- **Pitalkhora** is a western-ghat Hinayana chaitya.
- **Nashik Pandavleni**, also called Pondu Leni, holds chaitya and vihara caves of the western Deccan.
- **Junnar** (जुन्नर) holds chaitya and vihara caves.
- **Kanheri** is the largest cave complex in the Mumbai region. It has more than **100** Buddhist caves from about the first century BCE onward.
- Ajanta chaitya caves are caves **9** and **10** in the early phase and caves **19** and **26** in the later phase.
- Ellora cave **10**, called Vishvakarma, is a later rock-cut chaitya.

> **Logic:** Karle is the largest chaitya. Ajanta chaitya numbers are **9, 10, 19, and 26**.

3.10 Vihara

A vihara is a monastery. Cells stand around a courtyard or a central hall.

- A vihara houses monks. It is not a prayer-hall chaitya.
- Most Ajanta caves are viharas. Caves **1, 2, 16, and 17** carry the famous murals.
- Nashik Pandavleni has viharas.
- Kanheri has viharas.
- Nagarjunakonda has monasteries of the ayaka belt.

- **Nalanda** (नालंदा) is a Gupta–Pala mahavihara. Bakhtiyar Khilji burnt it in **1193**.
- **Vikramashila** (विक्रमशिला) is a Pala mahavihara founded by **Dharmapala** (धर्मपाल).
- **Odantapuri** (उदंतपुरी) is a Pala mahavihara.
- Sarnath has monastery remains beside Dhamek.
- **Bagh** in Madhya Pradesh holds Buddhist viharas with murals related to Ajanta.

> **Logic:** Ajanta mural stars are **viharas**, not chaityas. Nalanda is a mahavihara, not a stupa campus like Sanchi.

3.11 Rock-cut Architecture

- **Rock-cut Elephant at Dhauli (Odisha):** Sculpted directly from living rock during the reign of Mauryan Emperor **Ashoka** (3rd century BCE). Chronologically, it is the **earliest surviving rock-cut sculpture** in Indian architectural history (predating 5th-century Udayagiri Varaha, 7th-century Mamallapuram rathas, and 11th-century Lingaraja temple).

Rock-cut architecture is carved from living rock. It is not assembled from dressed blocks.

- Rock-cut is a **method**. The finished work may be a chaitya, a ratha, or a cave temple.
- **Barabar** (बराबर) and **Nagarjuni** in Bihar are Mauryan. Patrons are **Ashoka** and **Dasharatha**. The users are **Ajivikas** (आजीविक). The polish is Mauryan.
- **Lomas Rishi** at Barabar has the earliest surviving chaitya-arch facade.
- **Sudama** (सुदामा) is another Barabar cave.
- **Karan Chaupar** is another Barabar cave.
- **Visva Zopri**, also called Vishvakarma, completes the Barabar set.
- The nearby **Nagarjuni** group belongs to Dasharatha. It holds Gopi, Vadithi-ka-kubha, and Vapiya-ka-kubha.
- Mandapas and rathas at **Mahabalipuram** are Pallava rock-cut work. Later lists name the five rathas after the Pandavas and Draupadi. That naming is a later misnomer.
- Pallava work runs Mahendra mandapas, then Mamalla rathas, then Rajasimha's structural Shore Temple. The rathas are rock-cut. The Shore Temple is structural.
- **Ellora Cave 16**, the **Kailasa**, is the world's largest monolithic temple. **Rashtrakuta Krishna I** had it cut **top-down** in **Dravida** rock-cut form to recall Mount Kailasa. It is not Elephanta.

> **Logic:** Rathas at Mahabalipuram are **rock-cut**. Brihadeeswara is **structural**. Kailasa is Ellora cave 16, not Elephanta.

3.12 Cave Architecture

Cave architecture is numbered cave complexes of Buddhist, Hindu, and Jain use. UNESCO cave sites sit here.

- **Ajanta** sits in the Waghora gorge in Aurangabad / Chhatrapati Sambhaji Nagar district, Maharashtra. It is **Buddhist only**. UNESCO listed it in **1983**.
- Ajanta has about **30** numbered caves. The early phase is Satavahana Hinayana, about the second century BCE. The later phase is Vakataka Mahayana of the fifth–sixth centuries under **Harishena**.
- Ajanta chaityas are caves **9, 10, 19, and 26**.
- Viharas **1, 2, 16, and 17** carry the famous murals.
- Cave **1** holds **Padmapani**. Cave **17** preserves rich Vakataka painting, including Wheel-of-Life type themes. Full mural teaching sits in the Painting chapter.
- Ajanta murals are tempera on dry plaster. They show Jataka cycles. They are not true Italian fresco.
- The other famous Gupta-age Buddhist mural cousin is **Bagh** in Madhya Pradesh. It is not Ellora. It is not Nasik. It is not Lomas Rishi.
- **Ellora** is in Maharashtra. UNESCO listed it in **1983**. There are **34** caves from the sixth to the tenth century.
- Ellora caves **1–12** are Buddhist. Cave 10 is the Vishvakarma chaitya.
- Ellora caves **13–29** are Hindu. Cave **16** is Kailasa, cut under **Krishna I**.
- Ellora caves **30–34** are Jain. **Chhota Kailasa** sits in the Jain group. Indra Sabha is cave **32**.
- Rashtrakuta courts also patronised Jain scholars. **Amoghavarsha I** was a disciple of **Jinasena**, author of the *Adipurana*.
- **Elephanta** is Gharapuri island in Mumbai harbour. UNESCO listed it in **1987**. The main caves are **Shaiva** rock-cut work of Rashtrakuta-age patronage. A smaller Buddhist cave group also exists.
- Elephanta is celebrated for its monumental rock-cut **Trimurti** (or **Maheshamurti**), depicting the three aspects of Shiva: Aghora (Bhairava/fierce), Tatpurusha (serene), and Vamadeva (gentle/creative). It is Shaivite and distinct from Buddhist Ajanta and Ellora's monolithic Kailasa.
- **Sittanavasal** in Tamil Nadu is a **Jain** cave shrine of Pallava age. Do not merge it with Ajanta’s Buddhist murals.
- **Badami** has four Chalukya caves. Cave 3, a Vishnu cave of Mangalesha, is the largest. Badami is not India’s oldest rock-cut work. Barabar and the Bhimbetka horizon are earlier.
- **Udayagiri** and **Khandagiri** (खंडगिरि) near Bhubaneswar are Jain. The **Hathigumpha** inscription at Udayagiri belongs to **Kharavela** (खारवेल).
- **Rani Gumpha** there is double-storeyed.
- **Ganesh Gumpha** is another named cave in that Odisha pair.
- **Udayagiri** near Vidisha in Madhya Pradesh is Gupta. The Varaha panel belongs to Chandragupta II. It is not the Odisha Udayagiri.
- **Jogeshwari** is a Hindu cave of the Mumbai region.
- **Mandapeshwar** is another Hindu cave of the Mumbai region.

> [!TIP] **Exam Anchor [UPPCS Prelims 2018, Q16]:** Hathigumpha inscription of Kharavela on Udayagiri hills. *(See Q9 in Complete PYQ Bank below)*

3.13 Indo-Islamic Architecture

Indo-Islamic architecture brings the true **arch**, the **dome**, the **minaret**, mortar, calligraphy, *jali* (जाली), and arabesque from the late-twelfth-century Sultanate.

- Pre-Islamic India usually used the **corbel**. **Alai Darwaza** is the textbook **true arch** and **true dome**.
- A **squinch** is the early device that sets a dome on a square. A **pendentive** is the later curved-triangle device.
- Delhi building runs Slave, then Khilji, then Tughlaq with battered sloping walls and austere rubble, then Sayyid–Lodi garden tombs, then Sur.

Qutub complex (Delhi — not Uttar Pradesh)

Qutb-ud-din **Aibak** began the minar about **1193–99**. **Iltutmish** raised storeys **1–4**. **Firoz Shah Tughlaq** (फिरोज शाह तुगलक) added the fifth storey and repairs. Height is about **72.5** m. UNESCO listed the complex in **1993**.

- The minar uses red sandstone with marble bands on the upper storeys. It has about **379** steps. Afghan *minars* such as Jam inspired it, but the result is an Indian synthesis.
- **Quwwat-ul-Islam** (कुव्वत-उल-इस्लाम) mosque was begun by Aibak on debris of demolished temples.
- The iron pillar in the courtyard is Gupta. It is linked with **Chandragupta II** (चंद्रगुप्त द्वितीय) / Mehrauli and resists rust.
- **Alai Darwaza**, built by Alauddin Khilji in **1311**, is the first true dome of the complex.
- The incomplete **Alai Minar** was meant to dwarf Qutub.
- Iltutmish's tomb stands in the same complex. Qutub is **Delhi**. Never park it in Uttar Pradesh.

Delhi Sultanate — dynasty list

Slave / Mamluk

- **Quwwat-ul-Islam** is Aibak's congregational mosque at the Qutub complex.
- **Qutub Minar** (कुतुब मीनार) was begun by Aibak and raised by Iltutmish.
- **Adhai Din Ka Jhopra** at Ajmer is Aibak's mosque on a Sanskrit college site.
- **Sultan Garhi** is Iltutmish's tomb. It is remembered as the first Islamic mausoleum in India.
- **Balban's tomb** and the **Red Palace (Lal Mahal)** belong to the later Slave house.

Khilji

- **Siri** fort is Alauddin's Delhi.
- **Hauz Khas** is his reservoir campus.
- **Alai Darwaza** is his gateway at Qutub.
- **Alai Minar** is the unfinished giant minar.
- **Jamat Khana Masjid** stands at Nizamuddin.

Tughlaq

- **Tughlaqabad** (तुगलकाबाद) was built by Ghiyasuddin.
- Ghiyasuddin's tomb uses battered walls.

- **Firoz Shah Kotla** is Firoz's Delhi citadel.
- **Khirki** mosque uses a cross-vault.
- **Begumpur** mosque also uses a cross-vault.

Sayyid–Lodi

- Lodi Garden tombs are octagonal or square garden mausoleums.
- **Sikandar Lodi's tomb** stands in that garden set.
- **Moth ki Masjid** belongs to the Lodi world.

Provincial Sultanate

- **Atala Masjid** (अटाला मस्जिद) at Jaunpur was built about **1408** by **Ibrahim Shah Sharqi**. It is in **Uttar Pradesh**.
- **Lal Darwaza** and the Jama Masjid at Jaunpur use tall *propylon* screens. They do not use Delhi-type minarets.
- **Mandu** holds the Jami Masjid, Hindola Mahal, and Jahaz Mahal. Adina is not at Mandu.
- **Adina Masjid** is at **Pandua** in Bengal. Sikandar Shah built it.
- **Dakhil Darwaza** is at Gaur.
- The **Eklakhi** tomb at Gaur uses brick and terracotta.
- **Tin Darwaza** is at Ahmedabad.
- **Sidi Saiyyed** jali at Ahmedabad uses the palm motif.
- **Champaner–Pavagadh** in Gujarat is a UNESCO provincial campus.
- **Gol Gumbaz** (गोल गुम्बद) at Bijapur is the tomb of **Muhammad Adil Shah**. It has a whispering gallery.
- **Charminar** (चारमीनार) at Hyderabad was built by **Muhammad Quli Qutb Shah** in **1591**.

Sher Shah Suri

- Sher Shah's tomb at **Sasaram** in Bihar, about **1545**, is octagonal. It prefigures Mughal garden-tomb scale.
- In Delhi he left **Purana Qila** and the **Qila-i-Kuhna** mosque.
- In addition to his architectural monuments, Sher Shah reconstructed and expanded the ancient arterial highway (*Sadak-e-Azam*, later known as the Grand Trunk Road) connecting Sonargaon in Bengal to Attock in the Punjab.

> [!TIP] **Exam Anchor [UPPCS Prelims 2022, Q4]:** Sultan Garhi = Iltutmish; Red Palace = Balban; Jamat Khana = Alauddin Khalji; Kotla Firoz Shah = Firoz Shah Tughluq. *(See Q3 in Complete PYQ Bank below)*
>
> [!TIP] **Exam Anchor [UPPCS Prelims 2018, Q19]:** Adina Masjid is in **Pandua (Bengal)** built by Sikandar Shah, NOT in Mandu (MP). *(See Q10 in Complete PYQ Bank below)*

3.14 Mughal Architecture

Mughal architecture is the charbagh garden-tomb, the shift from red sandstone to marble, *pietra dura* (पिएत्रा ड्यूरा), the **double dome**, *chhatri*, *jharokha*, and the *hasht-bihisht* eight-paradise plan.

By emperor

Babur (बाबर)

- Babur laid **charbagh** gardens in India.
- **Ram Bagh**, also called Aram Bagh, at Agra is his garden type.
- **Kabuli Bagh** mosque stands at Panipat.
- Babur's tomb is at **Kabul**, not at Delhi.

Humayun (हुमायूँ)

- Humayun's tomb stands at **Delhi** near Nizamuddin.
- **Bega Begum**, also called Haji Begum, commissioned it. The architect was **Mirak Mirza Ghiyas**.
- Work runs about **1565–72**. It is the first major Indian garden tomb. UNESCO listed it in **1993**. It is the prototype of the Taj.

Akbar (अकबर)

- **Agra Fort** is Akbar's red-sandstone circuit. Jahangiri Mahal and Akbari Mahal sit inside it.
- **Fatehpur Sikri** was the capital about **1571–85**.
- **Allahabad Fort** is also Akbar's.
- The tomb at **Sikandra** was started by Akbar and finished by Jahangir.

Jahangir (जहाँगीर)

- Jahangir's own tomb is at **Shahdara, Lahore**.
- **Itimad-ud-Daulah** at Agra was built by **Nur Jahan** (नूरजहाँ). It is the first major **white marble** tomb with **pietra dura**. Coaching notes call it the Baby Taj.
- The Moti Masjid at Agra Fort is **Shah Jahan's**, not Jahangir's.

Shah Jahan (शाहजहाँ)

- The **Taj Mahal** stands at Agra.
- The **Red Fort** at Delhi was built in **1639–48**.
- **Jama Masjid** (जामा मस्जिद) at Delhi is Shah Jahan's Friday mosque.
- **Moti Masjid** (मोती मस्जिद) inside Agra Fort is his white-marble private mosque.

Aurangzeb (औरंगजेब)

- **Bibi ka Maqbara**, the tomb of Rabia Daurani at Aurangabad about **1660**, is called the poor man's Taj.
- Aurangzeb's **Moti Masjid** sits inside Delhi's Red Fort.
- **Badshahi Mosque** at Lahore is his congregational mosque.

Fatehpur Sikri (Uttar Pradesh)

Akbar | UNESCO 1986 | capital for about 15 years, then abandoned for water

- **Buland Darwaza** commemorates the **Gujarat victory of 1573**. It does not mark the birth of Salim / Jahangir. Jahangir was born in **1569**.
- The Jama Masjid of Sikri holds the white-marble **dargah of Salim Chishti** in its courtyard.
- **Panch Mahal** (पंच महल) is a five-storey open pavilion.
- The **Diwan-i-Khas** (दीवान-ए-खास) has a central **throne pillar**.
- The **Diwan-i-Aam** (दीवान-ए-आम) is the public audience hall.
- Jodha Bai's palace and Birbal's house stand in the residential zone.
- **Anup Talao** is the ornamental tank.
- The **Ibadat Khana** (इबादत खाना) was Akbar's hall of religious debate.

Taj Mahal (Agra, Uttar Pradesh)

Shah Jahan | Arjumand Banu Begum (Mumtaz Mahal) | 1631 to about 1648/53 | UNESCO 1983

- The tomb uses Makrana marble on the Yamuna bank. The garden is a charbagh.
- Four minarets lean slightly outward.
- **Amanat Khan** wrote the calligraphy.
- Tradition names **Ustad Ahmad Lahori** as the architect.
- The dome is a double dome. Pietra dura uses coral, lapis, and onyx.
- The Taj is not a Sultanate building. It is not at Delhi. It is not Jahangir's tomb.

Agra Fort and Red Fort

- **Agra Fort** is UNESCO **1983**. Akbar built the sandstone circuit. Shah Jahan added marble palaces: Diwan-i-Aam, Diwan-i-Khas, Moti Masjid, and Musamman Burj or Jasmine Tower.
- **Red Fort, Delhi** is UNESCO **2007** as the Red Fort Complex. Shah Jahan built it on the Yamuna. The gates are Lahori and Delhi. The Diwan-i-Khas carries the line *If there is a paradise on earth…*

Tomb match

- Babur is buried at **Kabul**.
- Humayun is buried at **Delhi**.
- Jahangir is buried at **Lahore**.
- Shah Jahan is buried at **Agra** (आगरा).

Monument chronology

- **Atala Mosque**, Jaunpur, about **1408**.
- Then Sher Shah's tomb at Sasaram, about **1545**.
- Then Humayun's Tomb at Delhi, about **1570**.
- Then Rabia Daurani / Bibi ka Maqbara, about **1660**.

[!TIP] **Exam Anchor [UPPCS Prelims 2025, Q49]:** Khajuraho temples built by Chandelas (950–1050 CE); Kandariya Mahadeva is dedicated to Shiva. *(See Q1 in Complete PYQ Bank below)*

[!TIP] **Exam Anchor [UPPCS Prelims 2025, Q57]:** Virupaksha Temple = Hampi (Karnataka); Sun Temple = Modhera (Gujarat); Lingaraja Temple = Bhubaneswar (Odisha); Kailasanatha Temple = Ellora (Maharashtra). *(See Q2 in Complete PYQ Bank below)*

[!TIP] **Exam Anchor [UPPCS Prelims 2019, Q91]:** Chronology: Atala Masjid (Jaunpur, 1408) → Shershah Suri Tomb (Sasaram, 1545) → Humayun's Tomb (Delhi, 1565–72) → Rabia Daurani Tomb / Bibi ka Maqbara (Aurangabad, 1678). *(See Q6 in Complete PYQ Bank below)*

3.15 Ancient Indian Architecture

Span: Indus cities → Maurya → post-Maurya Buddhist work → Gupta temple

- Indus cities used a grid, baked brick, and covered drains. They had no true arch.
- The **Great Bath** is at **Mohenjo-daro** (मोहनजोदड़ो).
- The dock is at **Lothal** (लोथल).
- The reservoirs are at **Dholavira** (धोलावीरा), listed by UNESCO in **2021**.
- Mauryan pillars use **Chunar** sandstone, Mauryan polish, and a Persepolitan bell capital.
- The **Sarnath** capital has four addorsed lions and a dharmachakra abacus with bull, horse, elephant, and lion. It became the **National Emblem in 1950**.
- A separate four-lion capital stands at **Sanchi**, apart from the stupa.
- **Rampurva** has a bull capital and a lion capital on two pillars.
- **Sankisa**, also spelled Sankissa, has an elephant capital.
- **Vaishali** has a single-lion capital.
- **Lauriya Nandangarh** has a single-lion capital.
- **Lauriya Araraj** has a single-lion capital.
- The **Prayagraj** pillar originally stood at Kaushambi. Later inscriptions of Samudragupta and Jahangir sit on it.
- **Barabar** caves are Mauryan Ajivika chambers. **Lomas Rishi** has the famous facade.
- Megasthenes compared the wooden palace at Pataliputra with Persepolis.
- The life-sized **Didarganj Yakshi** (दीदारगंज यक्षी) (Chauri-bearer) found near Patna showcases the pinnacle of Mauryan polish on sandstone, serving as an iconic benchmark of Mauryan court sculpture.
- Post-Maurya Buddhist work includes the Sanchi and Bharhut stupas and the Western Ghat chaitya-vihara caves.
- Gupta builders raise the first Hindu **structural** temple. **Dhamek** at Sarnath belongs to this age.
- The **Heliodorus Garuda** pillar at Besnagar / Vidisha is **Vaishnava / Bhagavata**. It is not a Shaiva cave shrine.
- **Angkor Wat** in Cambodia was built by Khmer **Suryavarman II** in the early twelfth century at Yashodharapura for **Vishnu**.

- **Borobudur** on Java in Indonesia is a UNESCO Buddhist stupa-temple. It is not Angkor.
- **Naimisharanya** at Sitapur in Uttar Pradesh is a sacred-site architecture note. Tradition links it with Dadhichi's bone and Indra's vajra.

> **Logic:** Pillar polish and Barabar are Maurya. The first Hindu structural temple is Gupta, not Maurya. Angkor Wat is not Java's Borobudur.

3.16 Medieval Indian Architecture

Span: Sultanate, regional kingdoms, Vijayanagara, and Mughal

- **Hampi** is the Vijayanagara capital on the Tungabhadra. UNESCO listed it in **1986**. Talikota in **1565** wrecked the city.
- **Virupaksha** at Hampi is a living Shiva temple. Do not confuse it with **Virupaksha** at **Pattadakal**.
- **Vittala** at Hampi holds the stone chariot and musical pillars.
- **Hazara Rama** is a royal shrine at Hampi.
- **Lotus Mahal** is a court pavilion there.
- The **elephant stables** stand in the same campus.
- **Meenakshi** gopurams at Madurai are a Nayaka peak.
- **Kumbhalgarh** is known for its long wall.
- **Hawa Mahal** at Jaipur was built by **Sawai Pratap Singh** in **1799**.
- **Rani ki Vav** at Patan is Solanki. UNESCO listed it in **2014**.
- **Chand Baori** is at Abhaneri.
- **Ahom moidams** at Charaideo in Assam entered UNESCO in **2024**.
- **Maratha Military Landscapes**, listed in **2025**, cover **12** forts including **Gingee** in Tamil Nadu.

3.17 Important Monuments — Cards

This is the place, dynasty, and UNESCO spine only. Full teaching sits in the cards above.

- The **Taj Mahal** is at Agra in Uttar Pradesh. Shah Jahan built it. UNESCO listed it in **1983**.
- **Agra Fort** is Akbar's sandstone circuit with Shah Jahan's marble palaces. UNESCO listed it in **1983**.
- **Fatehpur Sikri** and **Buland Darwaza** belong to Akbar. UNESCO listed the city in **1986**. The gateway marks the Gujarat victory.
- **Qutub Minar** is at Delhi. Aibak began it and Iltutmish raised it. UNESCO listed it in **1993**.
- **Humayun's Tomb** is at Delhi, about **1565–72**. UNESCO listed it in **1993**.
- **Konark** is the Eastern Ganga chariot temple of the 13th century. UNESCO listed it in **1984**.
- **Khajuraho** is Chandela work in Madhya Pradesh. UNESCO listed it in **1986**.
- **Brihadeeswara** at Thanjavur is Rajaraja I's Dravida temple of **1010**.
- **Sanchi** is Ashokan and Shunga work in Madhya Pradesh. UNESCO listed it in **1989**.
- **Mahabalipuram** holds Pallava rathas and the Shore Temple. UNESCO listed it in **1984**.

- **Ajanta** is a Buddhist cave campus. UNESCO listed it in **1983**.
- **Ellora** holds Buddhist, Hindu, and Jain caves. Kailasa is cave **16**. UNESCO listed it in **1983**.
- **Elephanta** holds the Trimurti Shiva. UNESCO listed it in **1987**.
- **Sarnath** joins Dhamek and Chaukhandi in Uttar Pradesh. UNESCO listed it in **2026**.
